strategic consequences of falling behind. Initially, they saw the US as crucial to building India's economic capabilities to deal with the symbolic and potentially strategic challenge that China posed. Later, when that country posed a military challenge, they turned to the US for assistance and assurance as well, even signing an air defense agreement in 1963 that called for mutual consultations in the event of a Chinese attack on India. Sino-US rapprochement put an end to this source of convergence, but it has reemerged in the two decades since Prime Minister Atal Behari Vajpayee argued in 2000 that, "above all," shared interests in Asia demanded a closer US-India partnership.[7]

While China played a significant role in shaping US-India relations in the past, this history has not been explored in any great detail. Most studies of US-India relations have focused on the impact of Pakistan, the former Soviet Union, personalities, economics, culture, or the two countries' foreign policy traditions or ideologies. They have largely offered more explanation for estrangement than engagement, and for continuity than change, in the bilateral relationship.

Overall, in these analyses, consideration of the role of the other elephant —or, rather, dragon—in the room has been largely missing. The link between US relations with China and India, and India's relations with China and the US has been left unexamined. A few scholars have assessed how China shaped the US-India relationship, but only in the context of limited events, such as the 1962 Sino-Indian War or the 1971 Indo-Pakistani War, or very briefly as part of a broader study. Others have even dismissed this role. One scholar, discussing US relations during the Cold War, for example, stated, "Washington's policy toward India and Pakistan had its own trajectory that followed a different and separate path from that of US-China policy."[8]

As this book will demonstrate, however, those paths were not distinct. Washington's China policy shaped its India policy, and Delhi's perception of China affected how it dealt with the US. China was at times a source of tension in the relationship. However, it also helps explain, in large part, why the two countries continued to engage with each other, despite what an Indian official called a "range of irritants" in the relationship.